

INTERNAL ONLY

Position on Agentic Commerce

Agentic Commerce represents a transformative shift in digital retail where AI agents act autonomously on behalf of consumers to discover, evaluate, and even purchase products. Unlike traditional chatbots or basic automation, agentic commerce involves intelligent AI agents capable of multi-step reasoning and autonomous decision-making. These agents will eventually:

- Proactively identify needs based on calendar events, previous purchases, or life changes
- Research and compare products across multiple platforms simultaneously
- Negotiate prices and terms directly with merchants or other AI agents
- Execute complete transactions with proper authorization and spend controls
- Handle post-purchase activities like tracking, returns, and customer service

Answer Engine Optimization

Today, shoppers often start their research by asking answer engines (e.g. ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google) for a product recommendation. Most retailers will want to ensure their products are fairly represented by answer engines, thus the discipline of Answer Engine Optimization (AEO/GEO) is the next generation of SEO.

There are two basic ways answer engines get their product data. First, they use web crawlers that collect data from websites both during training and occasionally to stay updated. These “bots” can be blocked by retailers, or allowed – and when allowed, the webpages and metadata can be optimized so the bots get the best quality information.

The second option is to provide a product catalog feed directly to the answer engines. There are emerging standards in this regard, and since this is new, it is not widely available yet. Note that answer engines require slightly different data than traditional Google feeds, so there is additional work to be done.

Instant Checkout

After making a recommendation, answer engines want to offer immediate checkout. This is done either via a previously established integration or by sending an agent to the retailer’s website to perform a checkout using the customer’s data on file. The answer engine often takes a fee on the purchase. OpenAI and Perplexity are moving in this direction now, with Google, Meta, and Microsoft expected to engage soon.

An inherent issue with instant checkout is that the retailer doesn't own the experience and can't offer things like upsells, add-ons, loyalty, etc. but is still responsible for fulfillment and after-sale support.

A variant on this is answer engines offering AI Web Browsers: Perplexity has Comet and OpenAI has Atlas. These browsers can perform the above things themselves through frontend automation.

Expanded Assortment

A unique solution from Amazon is "Buy for Me." Amazon has web crawlers that locate unique products not sold by Amazon on third-party website. When a customer wants one of those items, Amazon sends an agent to the website to purchase the item on the customer's behalf. The products available today are limited.

What should retailers do?

Retailers need to be considering their agentic commerce strategy. It may be too early to act aggressively, but all retailers should be monitoring progress. Here are four key questions:

1. What is your strategy for **inbound agents/bots**? Are you blocking them or allowing them? (Many retailers don't know they are blocking agents because sometimes their CDN does it automatically.) Are you optimizing your product content so they get quality data? Are you proactively feeding them product data? How are you measuring whether your products are being recommended by answer engines?
 - ◆ We are working on a salesplay for AEO with partners.
2. What is your strategy for checkout on answer engine sites? Do you want to allow it? Do you want to proactively integrate to the answer engines for checkout? How might this impact your sales, ads, loyalty, etc.?
 - ◆ We are working with AgentCore to possibly support emerging standards (including the product feed referenced in #1 above.)
3. What is your strategy for **outbound agents**? Do you want to implement a similar "Buy for Me" capability to expand your assortment? (This is typically only for the largest marketplaces or brands with wholesale partners.)
 - ◆ This could be accomplished with ACP, MCP, and perhaps Nova Act.
4. What is your strategy for **onsite agents**? Do you have an intelligent chatbot that can assist shoppers on your site? How can you satisfy your customers so they don't start on an answer engine?
 - ◆ We have several demos and guidance for shopping assistants. GenAIIIC has options as well.

Q&A**1. What is OpenAI doing with agentic commerce?**

OpenAI published an open standard called Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP) with Stripe that defines how to provide a product feed to them, and what APIs to support to allow checkout. Etsy, Shopify, and Walmart have signed on.

2. What is Perplexity doing with agentic commerce?

Shop Like a Pro allows U.S.-based Perplexity Pro users to search for and purchase items from a wide range of merchants directly on Perplexity using a single click. They only support Buy with Pro with merchants who are compatible with their agent checkout experience.

3. What is Google doing with agentic commerce?

Google published an open standard called Agent Payments Protocol (AP2) that defines how agents can pay merchants. It doesn't seem to have as much momentum as ACP. Google has not announced any major retailers adopting it yet.

4. Does Amazon block agents?

Yes, Amazon seems to go back-and-forth letting Google crawl its product catalog so that Amazon products appeared in search results. But now Amazon blocks Google and other bots from traversing its product detail pages. We don't speak for Amazon, but it's likely this was done because (a) Amazon's product catalog is a very valuable data source, and (b) Amazon wants to preserve and protect the shopping experience on its site.

5. How does Buy for Me work?

Amazon has crawlers that find products on third-party websites and adds them to the Amazon catalog. When appropriate to offer those products, customers see a "Buy for Me" button. Clicking sends an agent to browse the third-party site, add the item to the cart, and checkout using the customer's data. This is all done with high security. Websites that do not want to participate can block the agent and/or opt-out.

6. What is the disagreement between Amazon and Perplexity?

Amazon has decided it prefers its customers to use Rufus, which was designed specifically for e-commerce. So it blocks agents, but Perplexity has either ignored or worked-around the block without permission.

The strategic question isn't "should retailers block agents like Amazon does?" but rather "how do retailers ensure they're discoverable and transactable when AI agents reshape shopping?" Most retailers will benefit from being agent-accessible because:

- They need traffic from wherever it originates (including AI platforms)
- The rewards from additional traffic/conversion will outweigh the risk of losing advertising revenue (if any)
- Being excluded from AI agent recommendations means being invisible to AI-native shoppers

AWS can help retailers and brands stay visible, optimized, and competitive in an agent-driven future.

7. Does ACP require use of OpenAI and Stripe?

ACP is an open standard, but for now only OpenAI and Stripe have implemented it. There are many other competing standards from payment providers like Visa, MasterCard, PayPal, and Forter. Retailers that chose to use ACP can still use their own payment processor.

8. What is an answer engine?

An answer engine is an AI-powered technology that goes beyond traditional search engines by providing direct, conversational responses to customer queries rather than just returning a list of links or search results. Answer engines include OpenAI's ChatGPT, Perplexity, Google (with AI Mode), Amazon Q, etc. Amazon Rufus, the shopping assistant available on Amazon.com, can be considered a specialized answer engine for e-commerce.

9. Why is agentic commerce a big deal? It just sounds like a better version of search.

The emergence of agentic commerce has many parallels with the emergence of web search. Today consumers can use answer engines to get very specific product recommendations, and in some cases, streamline the purchase. But agents have the potential to do even more, keeping your pantry stocked with very little human intervention, for example.

10. What ecommerce platforms support ACP?

So far, SFDC Commerce Cloud and commercetools have announced support for ACP and others are sure to follow. But many retailers will be looking for custom implementations. AWS services can help implement solutions quickly.

Here are some local technical contacts:

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